of Secretary General, the highest possible position under the structure of civil service left behind by the British. The Indian Foreign Service (IFS) was formally established in October 1946.

From 1947 to 1964, the senior-most bureaucrat in the Ministry of External Affairs was the Secretary General. In 1948, the ministry's organization was relatively simple. While the Secretary General was in charge overall, a foreign secretary looked after Europe, the USA, Latin America, China and Japan and was assisted by two joint secretaries, two deputy secretaries and two undersecretaries. The Commonwealth secretary handled relations with the United Kingdom, British dominions and colonies and Asia.[34]

Former foreign secretary Gundevia narrates how the Ministry of External Affairs functioned in India's early years. According to him, the Secretary General presided over a meeting of all senior officials at 10:30 a.m. every morning. Secretaries and joint secretaries 'trooped in strict order of precedence and sat down in strict order of precedence and marched out in the same order when the session was over. It was a coordinated meeting at which, mostly, telegrams that had come in overnight were discussed. You got precise instructions, always, from the Secretary General on what to do and what not to do.' [35]

After Nehru's death in 1964, the office of Secretary General was abolished. The administrative head of the Ministry of External Affairs since then is the foreign secretary. There were initially two other secretaries, earlier called secretary EA I (External Affairs I) and secretary EA II (External Affairs II) later redesignated secretary, East and secretary, West. The two other secretaries in the current organigram who are relatively recent appointees are secretary DPA & ER (Development Partnership Administration and Economic Relations) and special secretary (Americas), indicating the increasing importance of the United States and the Western hemisphere in Indian foreign policy.